



Djibouti



A city-state with a desert hinterland, Djibouti lies in northeast Africa on the Red Sea. Once known as the French Territory of the Afars and Issas, independence came in 1977.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly low-lying desert and semidesert, with a volcanic mountain range in the north.



CLIMATE

Almost no rain, though the monsoon is very humid. The 109°F (45°C) heat of summer is unbearable.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The main ethnic groups are the Issas in the south, and the nomadic Afars in the north. Tensions between them developed into a guerrilla war in 1991–1994. Smaller tribal groups make up the rest of the population, and the rural peoples are mostly nomadic. Wealth is concentrated in Djibouti city. France exerts considerable influence in Djibouti, supporting it financially and maintaining a naval base and a military garrison.



THE ECONOMY

Djibouti's major assets are its ports in a key Red Sea location.



INSIGHT: *Chewing the leaves of the mildly narcotic qat shrub is an age-old social ritual in Djibouti*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Djibouti

DATE OF FORMATION: 1977

CAPITAL: Djibouti

POPULATION: 864,200

TOTAL AREA: 8494 sq. miles
(22,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 97 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Somali, Afar, French*, Arabic*

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 94%, Christian 6%

ETHNIC MIX: Issa 60%, Afar 35%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Djibouti franc = 100 centimes